

Did the HDB Resale Portal Reduce the Need for Property Agents?

The HDB Resale Portal was launched in 2018 to simplify the resale process. Did it actually reduce the need for property agents?

2018

HDB Resale Portal launched

One common expectation was that a simpler digital process would encourage more buyers and sellers to complete transactions on their own, reducing reliance on property agents. We examined HDB resale and CEA transaction records from 2017–2025 to see whether that happened.



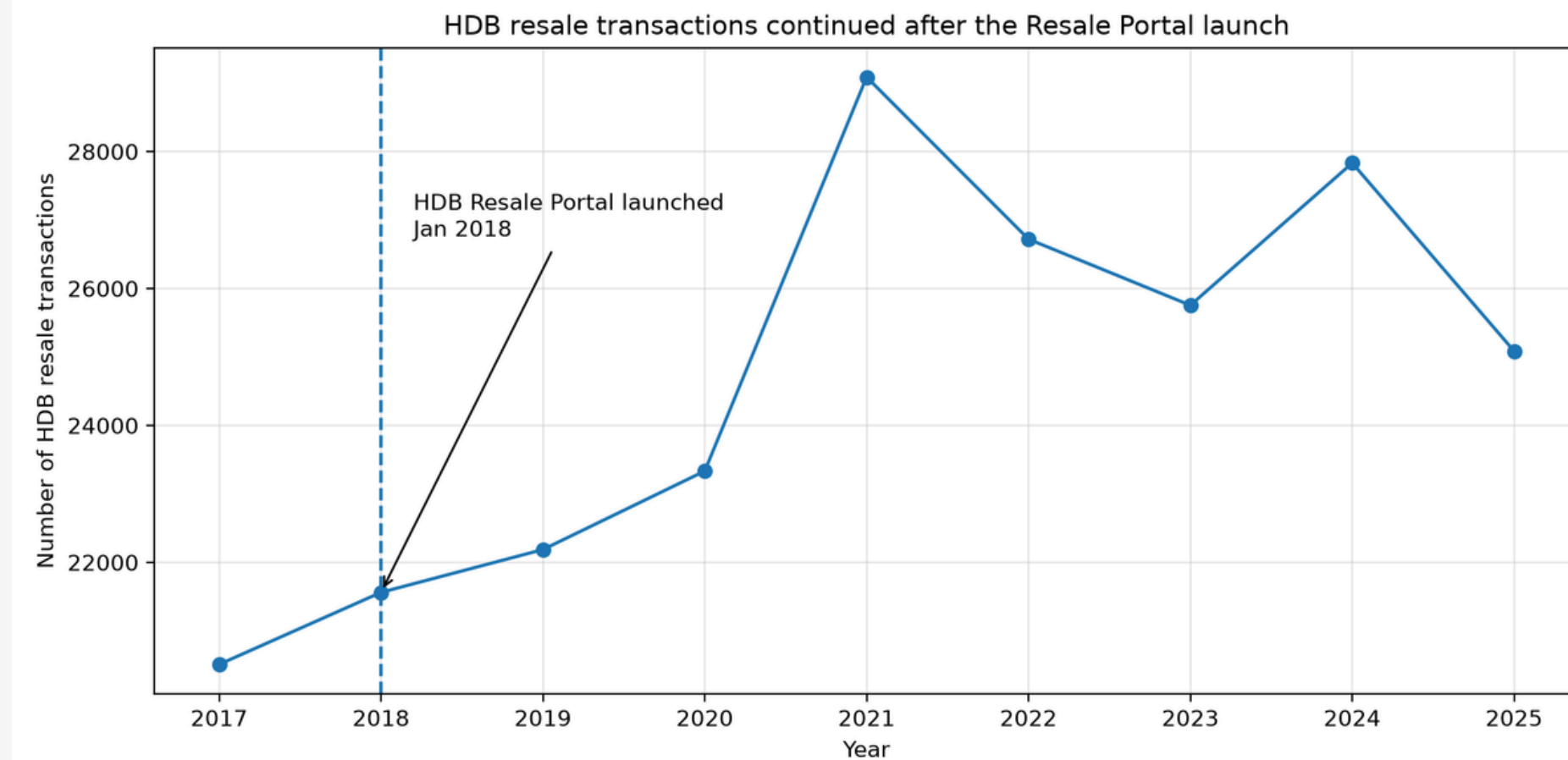
The resale market continued to grow after the portal was introduced

Key observations

Resale transactions increased after 2018.

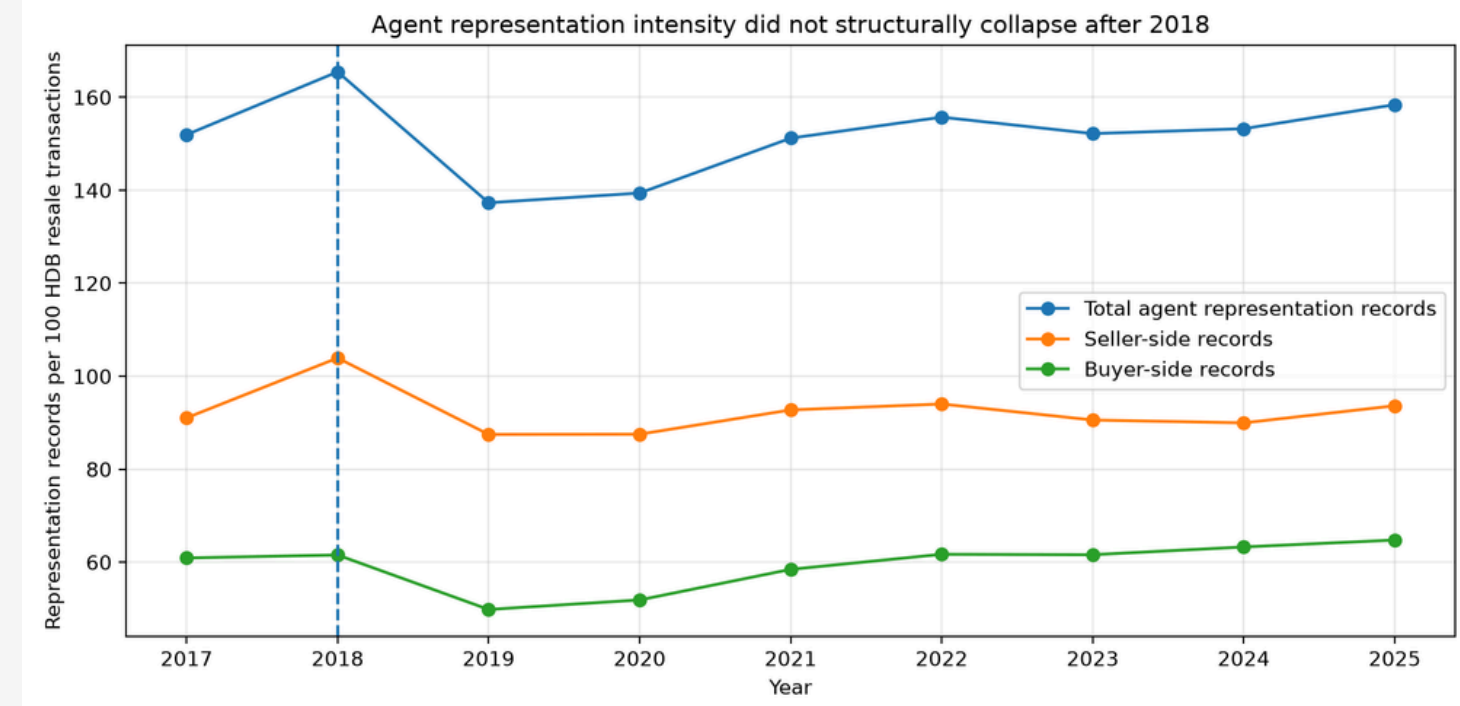
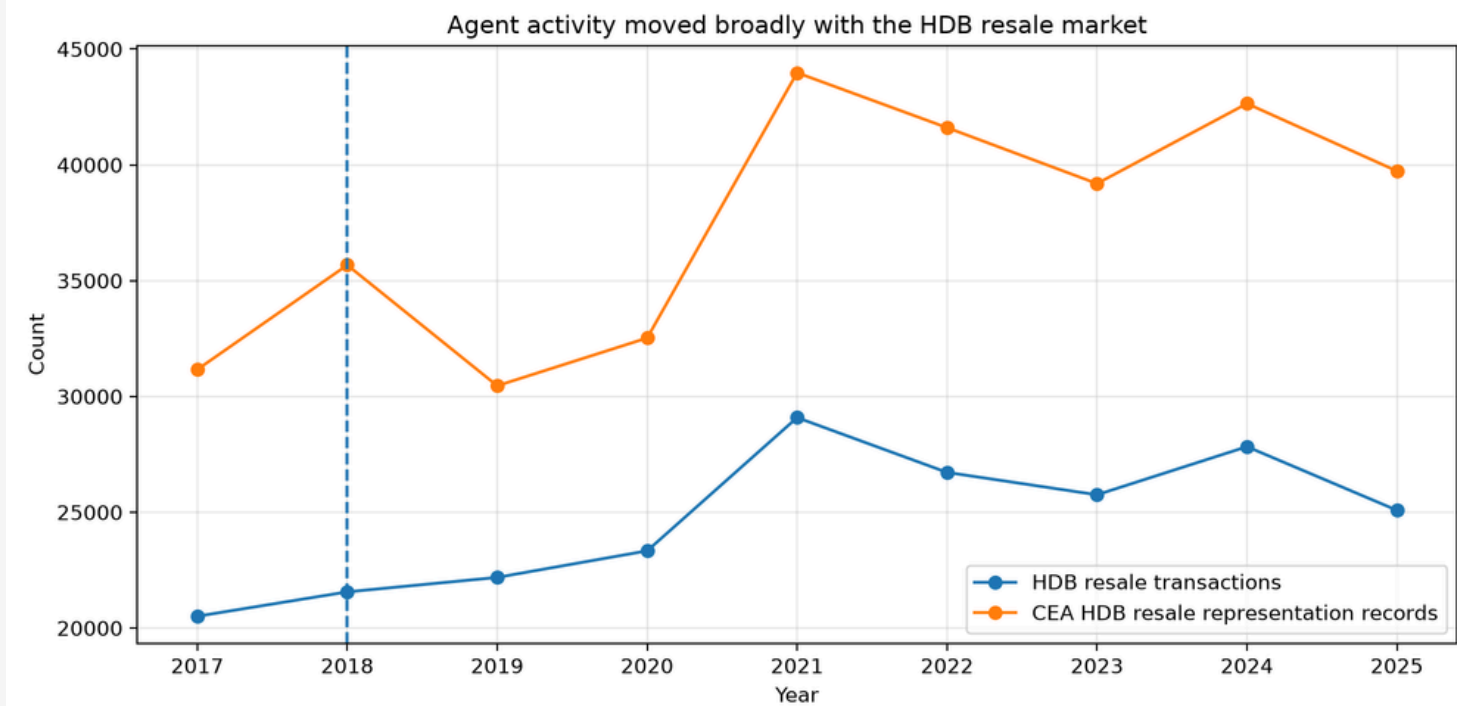
Annual resale volume remained consistently above the pre-portal level.

The portal did not reduce activity in the resale market.



Rather than shrinking the market, resale activity remained healthy throughout the post-portal period.

Property agents remained an important part of the resale market



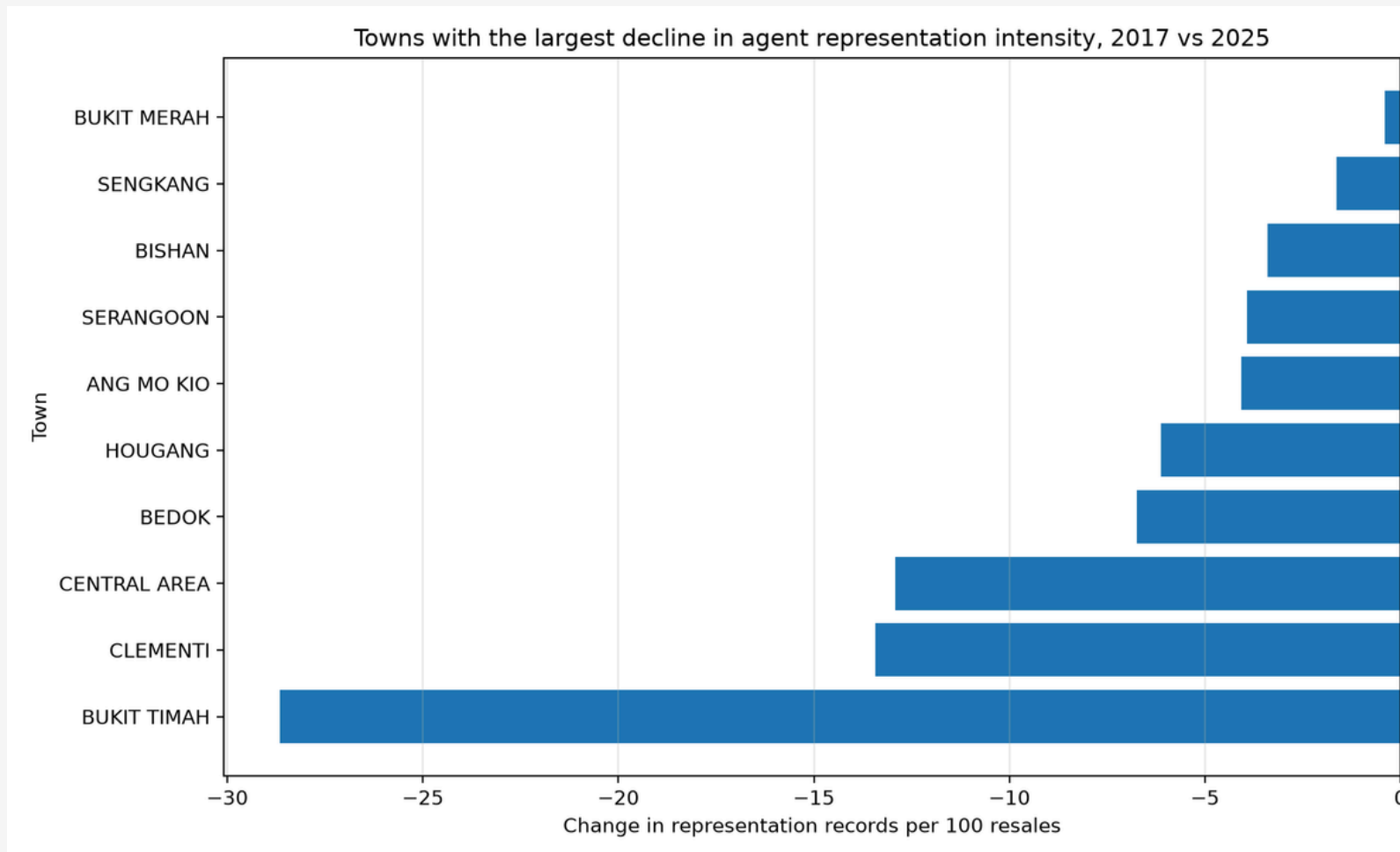
What changed?

Agent representation increased alongside overall market activity.

After adjusting for market size, representation intensity remained remarkably stable.

There is no evidence of a sharp decline in agent participation after the portal launch.

The impact varied across different towns



Town-level Difference

Not all towns experienced the same change.

Bukit Timah showed the largest decline in agent representation intensity.

Clementi and Central Area also recorded noticeable decreases.

Most towns experienced relatively modest changes, suggesting that the portal's impact was uneven across locations rather than universal.

Local housing market characteristics may play a larger role than the portal itself in determining the demand for property agents.

The portal changed how transactions happen—not whether agents are needed



Finding a buyer



Pricing & negotiation



Documentation & coordination

The evidence suggests

Digital tools complement professional services rather than replace them.

Although the portal simplified administrative procedures, many households may still rely on agents for pricing advice, negotiation, documentation, and transaction coordination.

Key Takeaways



Market

The HDB resale market continued to grow after 2018.



Agents

Property-agent activity remained broadly stable relative to market size.



Policy insight

The HDB Resale Portal appears to improve transaction efficiency without substantially reducing demand for professional property agents.

Digitalisation does not necessarily eliminate intermediaries—it often changes where they create value.

